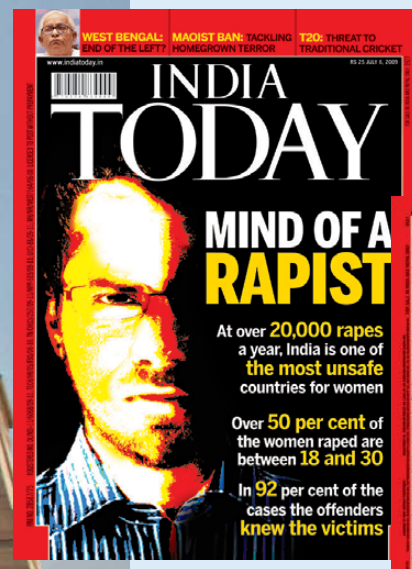


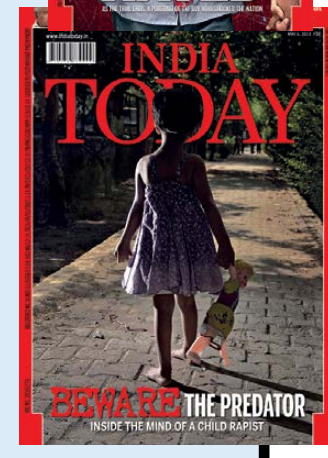
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▲ *Clockwise from top: Jan. 29, 2007; Aug. 5, 2013; May 6, 2013; May 30, 2005; Jul. 6, 2009*

Shame Without End

INDIA TODAY's cover stories across the decade showed a brutal continuity: crimes against women did not diminish, they mutated in form and scale while the system stayed inert. From child abuse to gang rape and political exploitation, the reportage exposed a nation repeatedly shocked, briefly outraged and then resigned to violence that never truly stopped.

Crimes against women were no longer episodic shocks but a sustained moral crisis. Public anger rose sharply, legal responses hardened, yet the underlying structures that enabled violence remained stubbornly intact.

The warning signs were already visible in the mid-2000s. A series of high-profile rapes in Delhi, Mumbai and Jaipur in 2005 underlined how vulnerable women were in public spaces, including police posts and moving vehicles. Opinion polls from the period showed that more than half of single women in major cities felt unsafe, and conviction rates remained abysmally low, reinforcing a culture of impunity.

The justice system, when it did act decisively, demonstrated its own contradictions. In 2006, the Delhi High Court overturned earlier acquittals in two emblematic cases. Santosh Singh was convicted for the rape and murder of law student Priyadarshini Mattoo, and Manu Sharma was sentenced to life imprisonment for killing Jessica Lall. These verdicts were celebrated as triumphs of perseverance and public pressure, but they also exposed how wealth, influence and delay had nearly buried justice in both cases.

The tipping point came on December 16, 2012. The gang rape of a 23-year-old physiotherapy student in a moving bus in Delhi was marked by a level of savagery that stunned even hardened investigators. The crime triggered an unprecedented public response. For weeks, young men and women occupied streets, defied police barricades and demanded accountability from the State. They reflected a generational anger that saw sexual violence as a failure of governance, policing and social attitudes combined.

The State responded with a speed that was rare by Indian standards. The Justice Verma Committee was constituted, and its recommendations led to sweeping amendments to criminal law in 2013. Definitions of rape were